STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 02 · You Are Not Crazy

Transcript · Wes Hart

Well. Look who came back. Good to see you. Last lesson we sat with a quiet Tuesday. Tuesday is where a man is made, or he settles. We said the four marks out loud. We talked about one small yes, the kind that's still standing after the feeling goes home. And I sent you out of here to go sit with men. Some of you did. Some of you, uh, sat near men. That counts too.

And some of you are in the exact same chair as the last lesson. Nobody assigned seats in here. Men just do that. Sit somewhere once, and it's yours for life. If you're new, you didn't miss the only door in. Grab a seat and stay a while. Nobody in here is a guest. That hasn't changed.

Here's what I'd bet happened. You went home and hit an ordinary day, and you meant to say the small yes. And somewhere in there, a voice in your head said, do it this way. And another voice said, no, a real man does the opposite. So you stood there. Tuesday in one hand, two sets of orders in the other.

That's what we're after in this lesson. Not the day. The noise on the day.

I want to say the claim first, so you hear it plain. You are not crazy.

I mean the man who wants a straight answer about what a man is for, and can't get two people to agree on it. That want is a good want. And the mess you feel about it isn't coming from a broken head. It's coming from somewhere. Let's go find where.

So let me tell on myself first. Years ago, well, more years than I'd like, a man I worked around told me, if you're serious, the work gets the first of you. Your family gets what's left. If you're decent, what's left is enough. I nodded. I heard grit in it. Same stretch of my life, an older man in a group I sat in said the exact opposite. He said, if your people get the leftovers, you already answered the question. You just answered it small.

So I tried to obey both of them. Same night. Stayed late, so the first man could be proud. Came home loud and helpful, so the second man could be proud too. I unloaded the dishwasher like I was on the clock, trying to win the evening back. My wife watched me from the doorway. She didn't argue. She didn't have to. I'd turned helping into a little show, and she could hear the show. Nothing says I'm right here with you like slamming the silverware drawer. Two men I wanted proud of me. Neither one of them lived in my house. She didn't need the contest. She needed a man who was actually in the room. I went to bed sure I'd failed them both. And, uh, I probably had.

One voice calls you selfish if you stay with the work. Another calls you soft if you leave it. You can hear both before supper and still not know which door is yours. You've run that one, right? Here's the part that'll mess with you. Both men meant well. Both of them were half right. And a man can't live by two half-rights that won't sit at the same table. So you pick one on Monday, the other one on Thursday, and feel guilty both days.

Ephesians four, verse fourteen. Then we will no longer be infants, tossed back and forth by the waves, and blown here and there by every wind of teaching and by the cunning and craftiness of people in their deceitful scheming.

Tossed back and forth. Blown here and there. Paul doesn't pretend the wind isn't blowing. He names it. Every wind of teaching. Some of it honest and wrong. Some of it not so honest. Now, notice who gets tossed in that verse. It isn't a wicked man. It's an infant. A man nobody finished raising. And hear this part. A boat getting thrown around doesn't mean the boat is crazy. It means there's weather. You with me? Last lesson we talked about a boy putting his childish ways behind him on purpose. Here Paul comes at it from the other side. Part of growing up is learning to stand in the wind without deciding the wind is your fault.

Listen. Most of us didn't invent the fight in our heads. We inherited it, and then we picked up a few more on the way.

There was a time the work sat where a boy could see it. He stood next to a man, and the knowing was in the man's hands. Now the work is across town. Or it's down the hall on a laptop, uh, with the door shut. The boy sees his dad leave, and he sees him, you know, come home tired. Everything in the middle is a rumor.

So nobody hands him one sentence for both places a man has to live. He grabs pieces. An uncle at a cookout hands him one. A group text hands him the other. And he nods at both. Then he grows up and tries to obey the whole pile. And when it won't add up, he figures the problem must be him.

Then a lot of rooms got shy. Saying God made a man on purpose started to feel risky. The old words got treated like a problem. Provide. Protect. Decide. Stay. A man could feel accused just for carrying them. Then the same world turned right around and mocked the guy who wouldn't grow up. Wouldn't stay. Wouldn't decide. It gave both orders. It just never said so out loud.

You can hear the fight on your phone, if you can stand it. One clip says strong makes you a threat. The next one says if you aren't strong, you're finished. Same afternoon. Same pocket. A coach tells a young man, take the room. Be first. Be loud. His first boss tells him, don't make a ripple. The guys who last around here are the quiet ones. He's, uh, twenty-two, and he's already got a headache. And nobody stops to admit they handed him both.

And I'm not here to swing at the church. I'm in it. We got, we got nervous about a plain sentence. So we handed out soft words, or we handed out loud ones. Neither one told a man what to do when he came home already used up. He got a pile. He needed a path.

Let me see where this sits in here. How many of you could name two instructions about being a man that can't both be true? Go on. Just a hand. Yeah. Look at that. That's most of the room.

So hear me. If you can name two orders that fight, you're not confused because you're slow. You're confused because you were listening. That's not a defect. That's a man paying attention to voices that should've agreed and didn't.

Genesis three, verse ten. He answered, I heard you in the garden, and I was afraid because I was naked; so I hid.

That's the first man. Right after the first wrong turn. God comes walking in the cool of the day, calling for him, and the man's answer is afraid, and covered, and hid.

Stay with me, because that's still what men do when the orders won't agree. The fight does three things to a man. I've watched all three. I've done all three. And I'd bet you have too. First, he hides by waiting. If every direction has been scolded by somebody, standing still starts to look polite. You call it patience. You call it not wanting to wreck the thing. I know the move. I stood at my own kitchen sink once and hid. I had a true sentence ready for my wife. It was about a bill we'd been dodging. Not a crisis. A decision with both our names on it. The plate in my hand was already dry. I kept drying it. For a good five minutes. Maybe ten. Then I asked if we were out of dish soap. Soap had an answer. The sentence didn't. And the bill didn't leave the house. It sat down at the table and got heavier. And she learned to quit waiting on the sentence. She stopped bringing it up. Not because it got settled. Uh, because soap was the only answer she ever got. I told myself I was being careful. Careful can be a stall with a clean shirt on.

How many of you went quiet because quiet felt safer than picking a side? Hands, if you're willing. Yeah. I see them. Me too.

Second, he covers by performing. The first thing that man did in the garden was sew something to hide behind. If nobody ever handed you one steady way, you start fitting whatever room you're standing in. I got good at the fit. An easy laugh when the guys were loose. A serious nod when the talk turned heavy. The man who had it handled if somebody important walked through. I wasn't trying to fool anybody. I was trying to match the temperature, and I got real good at matching. I've answered the same question two ways in one hour. Once on the back steps with a buddy, you know, the easy version. Once in the kitchen, a little later. Same facts. Different man talking. The buddy got one version. The kitchen got the other. Nobody asked me to switch. I offered. I've been a whole committee of men before the porch light came on. One set of keys. None of those men was quite me. They were, what's the word. Rented. And a rented man goes back at the end of the day. Here's the tender part. That man isn't a villain. Nobody gave him one way and stayed with it. So he studies the room, and he copies. Copying will wear you out. It just doesn't look like wear from the outside. People call it competence. If that's you, you can stop auditioning. The room can survive the real man. It might even be glad he showed up. Look, a performance can get you through a lot of rooms. It can't get you through your own front door. The people who live with you already know which one is you.

Third, and I want to go slower here. He carries shame.

Hand a man orders he can't meet, orders that argue with each other, and he usually doesn't blame the orders. He puts himself on trial. And he won't bring it up, because saying it out loud feels like making it official. So he carries it down the hardware aisle, through the, uh, school pickup line, and into the dark of his own room. He calls that being realistic. Call it what it is. A good man prosecuting himself for a contradiction he didn't write. I've carried one of those. I thought if I said it, it'd be the last word on me. So I smiled and kept moving.

I knew a man. I'll call him Ray. Not his name. We weren't close. I mean, I knew his truck better than I knew him. We ended up side by side at a parts counter one afternoon, both of us waiting on a belt for a dryer. The clerk went in the back. Ray's hands were nicked up from the day. He kept his eyes on the

counter. I could hear boxes moving back there. Neither of us was in a hurry to fill the air. It was one of those counters where the calendar on the wall is three years old. Ray looked wrung out. And it had nothing to do with laundry. Out of nowhere he told me he'd been saving up rules since he was a kid. His old man said, a man doesn't explain himself. You do the thing, and you keep moving. His first boss said, if you can't explain it, you don't understand it. So speak up. Two rules. Both of them sure of themselves. They'd never have shared a table.

Then he got married. His wife asked him not to go quiet on her. His brother told him, don't you give up the wheel. A man who gives it up is already done. Now, I want to be careful. I'm not siding with the brother, and I'm not making her the problem. I'm telling you the orders. I mean, both of them loved him. They fought. Ray pulled out his wallet and slid a scrap of paper out of it. Two lines, in his own printing. The crease had gone white. Years of folding will do that. Or years of reading. He said he read it in the cab of his truck before he walked into his own house. One line said, speak. The other said, don't you make a fuss. He looked at me and said, Wes, if I was smarter, these would fit.

I had— I had a little speech ready. I wanted to fix it fast. That's an old habit of mine. A speech, a point, a bow on top. I heard myself start, and I shut it down. He didn't need my speech. He needed the truth in a smaller size. So I said, Ray, you're not slow. Those two lines were never gonna shake hands. You've been carrying a fight in your wallet and calling it a personal failure.

He didn't rebuild his life at a parts counter. The clerk came back with the, uh, wrong belt, actually. But Ray put that scrap away a little different. Like it was smaller than it had been. He folded it once instead of twice. I noticed that. Sometimes that's where it starts. You see the fight was handed to you, and you quit treating your own name as the charge, fair?

Okay. I don't want any of this resting on my opinion, or on a scrap of paper in a man's wallet. So go back before the hiding. Two chapters back. Before anybody was afraid of anything. Genesis one, verse twenty-seven. So God created mankind in his own image, in the image of God he created them; male and female he created them.

Created. Not assembled by committee. Not left to chance. Male and female is on purpose in that sentence. God made us that way. In his image. And the man had nothing to show for himself yet. No résumé. No, um, track record. God called the making good anyway. He wasn't embarrassed of what he made. We got embarrassed later. That's on us. And it didn't happen all at once. We just got quieter about it, one careful sermon at a time. So that sense you've got, that being a man is a real thing, that sense is right. It's not a costume you try on. It's not a flaw in how he built you. It's one way the image of God walks around in an actual life. It was his idea. He wasn't guessing.

And your other sense is right too. The orders you've been handed don't agree. If you got turned around, look hard at what you were handed. Your own mind isn't the first suspect.

The Book hasn't been silent. We got embarrassed, or busy, or we got clever and called a pile a path, and we quit handing a sentence down. So wanting a plain word about what a man is for, that's a good hunger. Don't apologize for it. Bring it to the table. That hunger is part of how he made you.

Here's the thing, though. And a man will want to skip this part. Part of the gap is yours. Part of it was handed to you. You have to own both.

If you only own the world's part, the confusion turns into a hiding place. I know, because I've, uh, rented that place. If the orders fight, then nobody can say I missed mine. I called that being humble. It was a way to stay untested. You know, a hiding place with a humble sign on the door. Some of you went the other direction. You pleaded guilty to the whole mess. You confessed to being broken, when mostly you were worn out by a contradiction. That's a man swinging at himself with somebody else's stick.

Where you checked out, say so. Where the orders fought, name the orders. Keep both on the table. One will try to swallow the other. Don't— don't let it. I've seen men do both in the same afternoon. Blame everybody at lunch, and blame themselves by supper. Neither one is honest. Both are easier than the truth.

I watched a shrug get passed off as wisdom once. A younger man at a men's breakfast asked, plain, what's a man supposed to be for? An older man I trusted leaned his chair back. He said, shoot, nobody really knows. Just don't be a jerk. The younger man looked relieved, like the test got called off. And I get why the older man said it. He was tired of loud opinions. But that young man walked out poorer than when he walked in. A shrug can pass for peace. A younger man will copy it. It won't hold him up. A sentence will.

Now, where you're sitting changes the bruise. Look around for a second. You're not the only man in your kind of chair. Somebody two seats down is carrying the same fight in, uh, a different shirt.

If you're young, the guessing isn't proof you're behind. You got handed a loud pile early, that's all. If you're single, a wife is not the starting line of manhood. You can aim a life before anybody shares your name. A quiet apartment doesn't grade you. It's just quiet. If you're married, providing is a real weight. Honor it. It's just not the whole of you. If you've been hurt, I'll go slow. You can be wounded and still not be crazy. Naming the bad orders isn't a dodge of what you owe. It gets the clutter off the table, so you can see which weight is yours. If you're older, the years don't retire you from this. Somebody younger needs you to sort the pile with him, and leave the true pieces standing. Some of what you were handed still holds a family up. And if the job's going great, hitting every room's target isn't the same as knowing who to be in your own kitchen.

So what do you do with a pile. You don't need a taller one. You need one sentence that holds weight on a day when nobody's handing out credit. It's the one we said in the last lesson. You've already got it in your hand, and I'm not gonna unpack it here. You'll hear it before you leave. It's simpler than the pile. You can say it without notes. And it's harder than the pile, because you have to live it on a flat afternoon, when the feeling's gone home.

Let me land it. And then I'll get out of your way. Here's the big idea, one more time. The confusion is in the world. You were handed orders that fight each other. And you are not crazy for wanting one clear word about what a man is for.

The wind is real. Every wind of teaching. And the hiding is real too. Afraid, so I hid. We wait. We perform. We carry the shame and call it realistic. But before any of that, God made a man on purpose. And he wasn't guessing. He made you. Male and female, in his image, on purpose. It was never a costume. And it was never a mood.

So own both. Name the orders that fought. Own the part that's yours. Don't use the world as a blanket. And don't swing at yourself with somebody else's stick.

What I hope you carry out of here is relief. Not the kind that lets you off the hook. The kind that finally lets you pick up the right thing.

You're not the confusion. Your part is still yours. And you can quit carrying the rest. The rest was never yours. Somebody handed it to you, and you were too decent to put it down.

Last lesson I told you to go sit with men. This lesson, I'm asking you to tell them the truth once you sit down. Not the committee. Not the rented man. You.

Tell them the orders you were handed. Tell them which one you've been obeying. And tell them the one sentence you'd actually stand on.

The tables are ready. Open your workbook and work this part together. Don't polish it for me. Ugly and true will do. Don't explain the chapter to each other. And don't rescue a man from the question with advice. Advice can be a nice way to leave. Three questions. First. Name two instructions you were handed about being a man that contradict each other. Where did each one come from? Home. A job. A screen. A church. A buddy. One sentence each. Second. Which one is closer right now. You wait. You perform for the room. Or you carry a quiet hum of shame. Say the true one. Not the flattering one. Third. In one sentence, what do you believe a man is supposed to do? Don't write the one you wish. Write the one you'd say if nobody was grading you. Then read it to a brother at your table. Ask for his. Don't explain first. Explaining is how a man hides.

If you're doing this by yourself, you still write the sentence today, and you still read it to one man. A private project you mean to finish later is how this part dies.

The line for your handwriting is this. The confusion is in the world. I'm not crazy for wanting one clear word. Write it once. I'll say the four, like I promised, and then I'm done talking. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

Set down what God never asked you to carry. Pick up what's actually yours. Name the orders. Own your part. Write your sentence. Then go say it out loud to a man who'll say his back. Go to your tables, and tell the truth.